In a regional sense, the 1960 agreement between China and Myanmar was relevant to the conflict with India, as the border that was demarcated between those two countries follows the McMahon concept, i.e., the watershed principle. Myanmar's northern border is, in effect, a continuation of the McMahon Line, which China, evidently, does not see as an outcome of some old, colonial 'unequal treaty' or 'imperialist policies', the usual jargon that the Chinese government resorts to when the Sino-Indian border and other territorial disputes are mentioned.

The borders of Myanmar may have another bearing on India, and on the moves by the British in the 1930s to secure the McMahon Line. Myanmar, then known as Burma, had become a province of British India after the colonial conquest in the three Anglo-Burmese wars in the nineteenth century. But under the terms of the Government of India Act of 1935, Burma would become a separate colony. This happened in 1937, and according to Pradip Phanjoubam, this could have been 'one of the reasons why Olaf Caroe was in a hurry to publish the McMahon Line in *Aitchison's Treaties*—which he ultimately did in 1938 under controversial circumstances—[because of] this imminent separation' of Myanmar from India.[58]

British rule in northernmost Myanmar, albeit comparatively light compared to other parts of the colony, did extend to the northern watersheds, so it would make sense to secure the actual McMahon Line as well. A declassified 1959 US Central Intelligence Agency (CIA) document states that 'despite the drawing of the McMahon Line in 1914, almost nothing was done thereafter to extend administrative control into the hills.'[59] While the hills north of the Brahmaputra were neglected by the British, it is not entirely true that nothing was done. The same CIA intelligence brief says that although the area was largely unadministered, 'before 1900, the British had made pacts with various hill tribes designed from keeping them from raiding the plains dwellers'.[60]

Those contacts were not insignificant. Expeditions were sent into the mountains north of the Brahmaputra, and tribesmen from there would not only raid the lowlands but also go there to buy certain daily necessities not available in the highlands. With the exception of the Tawang area in the northwestern corner of today's Arunachal Pradesh and Walong in the far east, which traded mainly with Tibet, any contacts between the tribals of